Cardiology Service Line Handbook

MERIDIAN HEALTH PARTNERS
INTERNAL OPERATIONS POLICY MANUAL
SECTION 4: CARDIOLOGY SERVICE LINE HANDBOOK
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OWNER: DR. ARLO VANCE, CHIEF MEDICAL OFFICER

4.1 Purpose and Scope This document defines the operational parameters, patient intake criteria, scheduling durations, insurance tier mapping, and service level commitments for the Cardiology Service Line across all fourteen Meridian Health Partners facilities. Compliance with this policy is mandatory for all scheduling coordinators, intake specialists, and attending cardiologists.

4.2 Conditions Accepted and Explicitly Not Accepted

4.2.1 Accepted Conditions

The Cardiology Service Line is authorized to evaluate, diagnose, and manage the following outpatient conditions:

1. Essential and secondary hypertension (unstable hypertensive urgency must be routed to the emergency department).
2. Stable chronic coronary artery disease (CAD).
3. Compensated New York Heart Association (NYHA) Class I through III heart failure.
4. Paroxysmal or persistent atrial fibrillation managed under outpatient rhythm or rate control protocols.
5. Hyperlipidemia and metabolic cardiovascular risk assessment.
6. Palpitations and suspected supraventricular arrhythmias without hemodynamic compromise.

4.2.2 Explicitly Not Accepted Conditions

The following conditions fall outside the outpatient scope of Meridian Health Partners cardiology clinics and must be declined at the point of intake:

1. Acute myocardial infarction or suspected acute coronary syndrome (ACS). Unstable patients must be directed immediately to the nearest hospital emergency department via 911.
2. Decompensated heart failure requiring intravenous inotropic support or acute diuresis.
3. Complex congenital heart disease in pediatric patients under the age of 18 years (referrals must be routed to regional tertiary pediatric centers).
4. Advanced, uncompensated valvular disease requiring urgent surgical intervention.
5. Cardiac arrest survivors requiring post-resuscitation intensive care.

4.3 Appointment Durations and Scheduling Standards

4.3.1 Consultations and Follow-ups
1. New Patient Consultation: Allocated slot duration is strictly 45 minutes. This includes pre-encounter vitals, intake review, and physical examination by the attending cardiologist.
2. Established Patient Follow-up: Allocated slot duration is strictly 20 minutes.
3. Device Check (Pacemaker/ICD Interrogation): Allocated slot duration is strictly 30 minutes, performed by specialized cardiac technicians under physician oversight.

4.3.2 Diagnostic Testing Durations
1. Standard 12-Lead Electrocardiogram (ECG): 15 minutes.
2. Echocardiogram (Transthoracic): 45 minutes.
3. Holter Monitor Application: 20 minutes (with a standard 48-hour or 7-day wear period).

4.4 Patient Preparation Instructions

Intake staff must communicate the following mandatory preparation instructions to patients at the time of booking:

1. Fasting Requirements: Patients scheduled for a diagnostic echocardiogram combined with a pharmacological stress protocol must observe a strict 4-hour fast prior to arrival. Water and essential medications are permitted.
2. Medication Restrictions: Patients undergoing stress testing must withhold beta-blockers and calcium channel blockers for exactly 24 hours prior to the appointment, *strictly* upon the explicit written authorization of the referring provider or attending cardiologist.
3. Skin Preparation: For ambulatory ECG monitoring (Holter or event monitors), patients must shower prior to arrival and refrain from applying body lotions, oils, or talcum powder to the chest wall to ensure electrode adhesion.
4. Identification and Documentation: Patients must bring a government-issued photo ID, their current Meridian Health Partners insurance card, and a complete physical bottle-or-list of all current prescription and over-the-counter medications.

4.5 Insurance Plan Coverage Matrix

Meridian Health Partners operates four proprietary and partnered health plans. Coverage for cardiology procedures is governed by the following strict tier schedule:

Procedure / Service	MeridianSelect (Tier 1)	MeridianValue (Tier 2)	MeridianAccess (Tier 3)	MeridianChoice (Tier 4)
New Patient Consultation	Fully Covered ($0 copay)	Covered ($20 copay)	Covered ($40 copay)	Covered (Subject to deductible)
Transthoracic Echocardiogram	Fully Covered	Covered ($50 copay)	Covered ($100 copay)	Covered (Subject to deductible)
Ambulatory ECG Monitoring (Holter)	Fully Covered	Covered ($30 copay)	Covered ($75 copay)	Covered (Subject to deductible)
Pacemaker Interrogation	Fully Covered	Fully Covered	Covered ($50 copay)	Covered (Subject to deductible)
Electrophysiology Studies	Prior Auth Required	Prior Auth Required	Prior Auth Required	Not Covered

Named Exception: Patients enrolled under MeridianSelect presenting with acute symptoms referred directly by a Meridian primary care physician bypass prior authorization requirements for baseline ECG and echocardiography.

4.6 Referral Turnaround Commitment

1. Standard Referrals: The Cardiology Department commits to processing, reviewing, and contacting the patient to schedule all routine cardiology referrals within 48 business hours of receipt of the complete clinical packet.
2. Urgent Referrals: Referrals marked as urgent by a licensed provider (denoting unstable angina, rapid atrial fibrillation with controlled ventricular response, or recent syncopal episodes without red flags) must be triaged by a registered nurse and contacted within 8 business hours.
3. Incomplete Packets: If a referral lacks mandatory clinical notes or recent lab results, the intake desk shall issue a request for information to the originating provider. The turnaround clock pauses until receipt of the missing documentation.

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